

Chapter 43-1: Like

Since ancient times, achieving unity between person and sword had been extremely difficult. Ning Fuyi had never imagined that this divine sword would act on its own according to her thoughts. However, she couldn't stop it no matter how hard she tried, so she could only awkwardly hide further behind the tree.

Chu Qingqiu's expression was complex. She lowered her hand, and Ning Fuyi felt someone grab her arm, pulling and tugging her out from behind the tree. Ning Fuyi was thus exposed plainly before Chu Qingqiu, coughing as if unintentionally: "Divine Venerable, I'm practicing swordplay."

"Oh?" Chu Qingqiu's tone rose at the end, her peach blossom eyes looking at her without emotion. "You don't go to the back mountain to practice swordplay, but instead practice at the foot of this mountain."

"This place..." Ning Fuyi tossed her hair and looked around in a circle, barely squeezing out a sentence: "The scenery is nice."

Chu Qingqiu neither said she believed nor disbelieved her. She parted her lips slightly and instructed the bewildered Qiu Yi beside her: "Go help her up."

"Yes." Qiu Yi glared at Ning Fuyi, then quickly stepped into the grass and grasped the woman's arm to help her up.

The woman had obviously been knocked dizzy by the divine sword's strike. She swayed in place for a while before recovering, reaching up to pull the dry grass from her hair and forcing out a smile.

"The Divine Venerable's welcome is truly unforgettable," she said, pulling her wrinkled shawl from the grass. With a delicate twist of her fingers, the shawl returned to its original state and settled back on her arm.

"The disciples in our sect are not skilled in swordplay. We apologize for the offense," Chu Qingqiu shook her head, her gaze inevitably falling on the woman's reddened forehead. "This injury..."

"It's minor," the woman waved her hand dismissively, producing some ointment from somewhere and applying it. Her forehead immediately became smooth and flat again, and she winked at Chu Qingqiu.

She even threw a flirtatious glance! Ning Fuyi's eyelid twitched violently as she watched.

A whooshing sound crossed the sky, and a point of light appeared a hundred li away. In the blink of an eye, it was about to pierce through the woman's head. Ning Fuyi quickly leaped into mid-air, grasping the divine sword that was planning to continue its assault. Person and sword wrestled together in quite a spectacle.

The woman covered her chest and dodged to the side, her large eyes alternately looking at Chu Qingqiu and Ning Fuyi, her heart still pounding with fear.

"Yearning!" Ning Fuyi finally shouted angrily, forcefully stuffing it into her storage bead, finally ending this struggle.

"Your sect's sword practice methods are truly unique," the woman smiled again, her delicate hand covering her chest as she looked curiously at Ning Fuyi, though she quickly shifted her gaze away. "We were interrupted just now, Divine Venerable..."

"Very well," Chu Qingqiu ignored Ning Fuyi and agreed quietly, then extended her hand to the woman again.

Now that they were closer, one could see clearly that the two weren't caressing each other's palms, but rather placing their index fingers on each other's wrists. Several silver threads pierced their skin to examine the pulse.

So they were taking pulses... Ning Fuyi realized she had misunderstood, her cheeks slightly reddening as she looked away.

"Have you finished practicing swordplay? Why aren't you leaving yet?" Qiu Yi beside her spoke up challengingly.

"I won't," Ning Fuyi replied with a forced smile. Just as Qiu Yi was about to start another argument, Chu Qingqiu frowned and glanced at both of them, causing Qiu Yi to fall silent.

As the silver threads went deeper, the woman's smile disappeared. Her complexion didn't look good as she glanced at Ning Fuyi and Qiu Yi, wanting to speak but hesitating.

"You two, go back," Chu Qingqiu indicated to the pair.

"Hurry up and leave," Qiu Yi grabbed Ning Fuyi and dragged the reluctant her several zhang away, then found a place to hide and pricked up her ears to listen.

"Who is that person?" Ning Fuyi frowned as she looked at the two standing face to face, asking.

"Jiang Li from the Jiang family of Wushan¹, one of the four great families," Qiu Yi answered sulkily.

The Jiang family of Wushan was the only one among the four great families that primarily cultivated healing arts. They had hundreds of branch bloodlines distributed throughout the eight wilderness areas. Without exception, all Jiang family members studied medical arts. Therefore, although most Jiang family members' cultivation only lingered around the Immortal Body realm², they enjoyed great prestige in the martial world due to their service in healing and saving people.

Ning Fuyi had also heard of the name Jiang Li. She was the medical immortal with the highest medical skills in the Jiang family. As long as a patient hadn't stopped breathing, she could save them and restore a thread of life in her hands.

Ning Fuyi made a sound of acknowledgment.

On the other side, Jiang Li finally withdrew her silver threads and hand, speaking: "Divine Venerable, all your meridians have been injured by demonic energy. Although it won't endanger your life for now, your immortal meridians are shattered like cotton floss. If you don't properly repair and nurture them, you may lose your life."

"There's more," Jiang Li hesitated. "I also detected another injury within the Divine Venerable's body. It's been there for some time, seemingly from some kind of power backlash."

"This power is too strong. In my thousand years of practicing medicine, I've never seen anything like it. This type of wound will relapse every so often. When it flares up, it's like hundreds of steel nails piercing bone. Divine Venerable..." Jiang Li found it difficult to continue.

This kind of pain was unbearable for ordinary people, and it couldn't be cured at the root. She had seen many highly cultivated immortals take their own lives because of such conditions.

So seeing the woman standing gracefully before her, she couldn't imagine how she had silently endured such agony without anyone noticing.

"I'm aware of this. There's no need to worry about that matter. Just help me resolve the current injuries," Chu Qingqiu's expression didn't change, and she added: "As quickly as possible."

Jiang Li sighed. As a doctor, she wouldn't press the matter, so she could only agree.

She had only heard that Divine Venerable Chu Ling was stern and unsmiling, with unfathomable strength. She hadn't expected that meeting her today would be quite different from the rumors, yet she was even more intriguing than described.

"I have some pills here that are remarkably effective for pain relief," she smiled again, taking out two bottles filled to the brim and handing them to Chu Qingqiu.

Chu Qingqiu thanked her and accepted them, turning her body slightly: "Please."

The two walked side by side—one cold and silent, the other smiling charmingly. They looked quite pleasing to the eye as they slowly passed by Ning Fuyi, who hadn't overheard anything.

Qiu Yi lowered her head and followed behind Chu Qingqiu, while Ning Fuyi stood in place for a while before stepping forward to follow.

Footnotes:

¹ **Wushan (巫山)** - Literally "Witch Mountain" or "Shaman Mountain," a location known for its mystical associations in Chinese literature.

² **Immortal Body realm (仙身)** - One of the cultivation realms mentioned in the story's power system, representing a specific level of spiritual advancement.